Common Sense Extreme: populist and extremist narratives in European parliaments

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The rise of extremism poses a significant challenge to constitutional democracies. Extremism fosters divisive narratives, promotes hostility between groups, and perpetuates an "us versus them" worldview (Postigo Fuentes et al. 2024). This becomes especially alarming when combined with populist rhetoric in which the speaker claims to represent "the people" as a homogenous entity (Kock et al. 2022). Extremism's focus on in-groups and out-groups, perceived as homogenous, aligns with populism in positioning "the people" against elites or the "other". Moreover, populism often emotionalizes discourse, simplifies issues, and amplifies polarization which contributes to its persuasiveness (Zarefsky & Mohammed 2020). In parliamentary contexts, such strategies are particularly alarming due to their potential to shape legislative decisions and impact policy-making processes.

This study examines the relationship between populist rhetoric and extremist narratives in European parliaments by analyzing common sense narratives in speeches using corpus linguistic and data-mining techniques. As Fišer et al. (2023) note, terms referencing "the people", used as proxies for populist discourse, vary widely, making detecting populism in multilingual datasets particularly challenging. To address this, we use ParlaMint-en 4.1 (Kuzman et al. 2024), the English machine-translated version of ParlaMint 4.1, and focus on the distribution and context of the single-phrase query common sense.

ParlaMint-en 4.1 ensures good cross-linguistic comparability and offers a unique opportunity to observe social phenomena on a large scale, geographically and temporally, through unified queries. The corpus uses data from ParlaMint 4.1 (Erjavec et al. 2024b) which includes parliamentary debates with rich metadata from 29 European parliaments, covering at least the period from 2015 to 2022 and comprising over one billion words (Erjavec et al. 2024a). The data was machine-translated using EasyNMT and OPUS-MT models, and for this reason includes errors typical of neural machine translation (Kuzman et al. 2024).

Common sense narratives, as shown by Newth (2024) in his study of social media posts by Italian politician Matteo Salvini, help reference the people in populists' claims and lend them rationality. Drawing on Laclau's (1996) theory of empty signifiers, we understand common sense as a nodal point uniting collective identities while masking dominant, potentially extremist stances as universally acceptable. This motivates our use of common sense as a proxy for populist parliamentary discourse which we analyse with topic modeling and collocation analysis and interpret through the prism of key extremist topics. Querying and collocation analysis was done through noSketchEngine (Kilgarriff 2014), hosted at CLARIN.SI. For topic modelling, we used the LDA-algorithm, available in Orange (Demšar et al. 2013). Extremist topics were identified based on extremist narratives described in Forti (2024) and Wilson and Hainsworth (2012).

The analysis considers factors such as party political orientation, government-opposition dynamics, and speaker gender, along with temporal and geographical variations. Our findings, shown in Figure 1, support prior observations (Rodríguez-Pose 2020; Trencsényi et al. 2024) that populism is rising and surges during crises. While far-right politics is well known for featuring populist discourse, we observe common sense narratives across the political spectrum, especially at the extremes (relative frequencies: centrist parties 11.8, right-wing 13.9, left-wing 16.5).

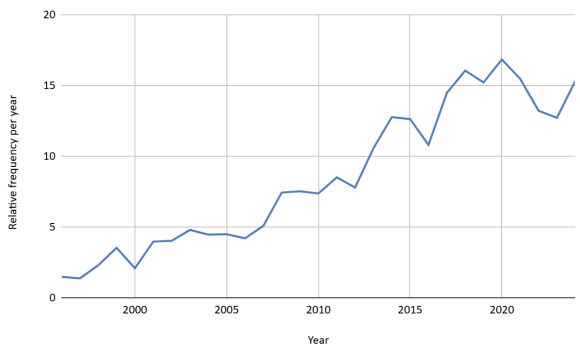

Figure 1: Temporal distribution of common sense across 29 European parliaments.

Gender and parliamentary power dynamics also influence the use of common sense. While the difference between male and female speakers is less pronounced (13.2 vs. 10.9 per million words), opposition MPs invoke the phrase nearly twice as often as coalition MPs. This aligns with Fišer & Pahor de Maiti (2021) who wrote on gender impact on Slovene parliamentary discourse and Tuttnauer (2018) who analysed opposition behavior in European parliaments, suggesting a gendered dimension to populist language and its rhetorical utility for challenging the establishment.

Moreover, we investigate the overlap of common sense and extremist narratives. Topic analysis reveals that while common sense narratives can reinforce extreme ideological positions, such as those on migration and environmental policies, they often serve rhetorical purposes, in particular to hinder debate by framing positions as self-evident truths and establish the speaker as the true representative of voters.

By examining common sense narratives across Europe, we highlight how populist rhetoric shapes public discourse and supports extremist positions. Unlike studies focused on specific parties or figures, our approach, using the ParlaMint-en corpus which includes all parliamentary actors for a given period, provides a more comprehensive view of parliamentary discourse and dynamics. This demonstrates the value of digital methods and open-access data in advancing research on populism and political communication, contributing to efforts for more inclusive and evidence-based democratic practices.

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